

DEEP-DIVE #1

The ARPA Cliff

A research brief on how temporary American Rescue Plan arts relief moved through federal, state, and local systems — and what happens as those dollars run off at the end of 2026. Built from primary sources at the National Endowment for the Arts, the U.S. Treasury, the National League of Cities, the National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, Arts Midwest, and individual state and municipal recovery programs.

Byline

Bitcoin for the Arts Research

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Citation

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\$135M

NEA ARP ALLOCATION

American Rescue Plan funding allocated to the National Endowment for the Arts for arts-sector recovery. ^[1]

\$350B

STATE/LOCAL RECOVERY FUND

Coronavirus State and Local Fiscal Recovery Funds made available to state, local, territorial, and Tribal governments. ^[5]

567

2026

DIRECT NEA ORG GRANTS

Arts organizations recommended for direct NEA American Rescue Plan grants totaling \$57.75M. ^[4]

SLFRF SPEND DEADLINE

Municipalities had until December 2026 to spend obligated SLFRF dollars. ^[6]

Abstract

A research brief on how temporary American Rescue Plan arts relief moved through federal, state, and local systems — and what happens as those dollars run off at the end of 2026. Built from primary sources at the National Endowment for the Arts, the U.S. Treasury, the National League of Cities, the National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, Arts Midwest, and individual state and municipal recovery programs.

WHY THIS BRIEF EXISTS

Bitcoin for the Arts Research is the public research program of Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc., a 501(c)(3) nonprofit. Every claim in this document is traceable to a primary source. The institutional byline is "Bitcoin for the Arts Research" — there are no personal bylines on BFTA reports. See the live web version for the full report; this PDF is the citable, print-ready brief.

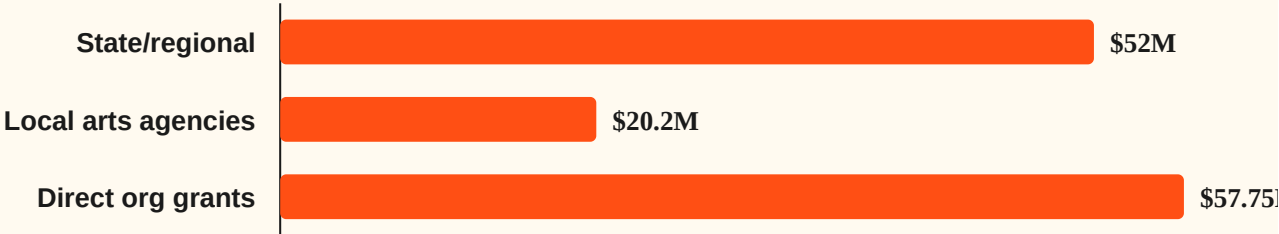
Report structure

- 01 What the cliff actually looks like
- 02 Why cities cannot replace the cliff
- 03 Who gets hit first
- 04 What Bitcoin has to do with this
- 05 State-by-state source table

Headline charts

NEA American Rescue Plan arts funding moved through three channels

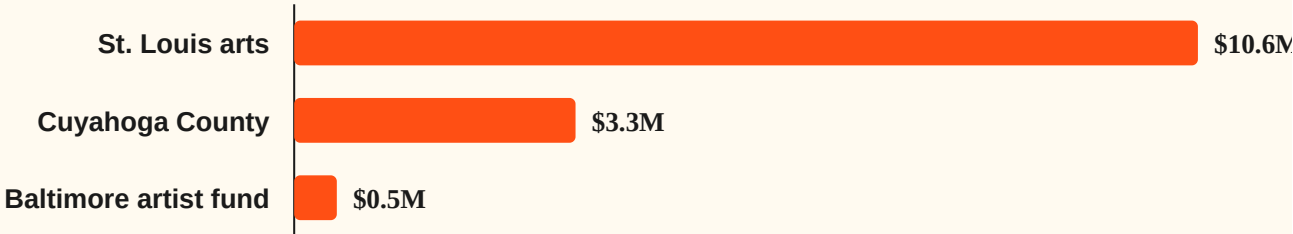
The \$135M NEA allocation included state/regional regranting, local arts agency subgranting, and direct grants to arts organizations.



Sources: National Endowment for the Arts, The American Rescue Plan; National Endowment for the Arts, ARP state and regional arts agency funding announcement; National Endowment for the Arts, American Rescue Plan Grants to Local Arts Agencies; National Endowment for the Arts, American Rescue Plan Grants to Arts Organizations.

Selected local and state ARPA arts interventions varied widely in scale

Examples show how flexible recovery dollars were adapted to different local arts ecosystems.



Sources: National League of Cities, Ways that Cities Are Directing ARPA Dollars Toward the Arts; Pennsylvania Department of Community & Economic Development, COVID-19 ARPA PA Arts and Culture Recovery Program; Assembly for the Arts, Cuyahoga County ARPA funds for arts nonprofits and creative workers; Baltimore Civic Fund, 2025 ARPA Artist Grant Fund.

Post-relief state arts appropriations entered FY2026 below FY2025

Arts Midwest's summary of NASAA FY2026 data reports national state arts agency appropriations falling from \$694.3M to \$646.0M.



Source: Arts Midwest, Public Funding for the Arts in the Midwest: 2026 by the Numbers.

Where to read the full report

The complete, web-rendered version of this report — with full narrative text, source-linked footnotes, and any updates posted since this PDF was generated — lives at bitcoinforthearts.org/research/the-arpa-cliff. The canonical, citable chart-data JSON behind every number in this brief is published at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research.

"If we do not have a reference, we do not publish the data. Period." — BFTA Research methodology

References

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- [2] National Endowment for the Arts, ARP state and regional arts agency funding announcement. <https://www.arts.gov/COVID-19/the-american-rescue-plan>
- [3] National Endowment for the Arts, American Rescue Plan Grants to Local Arts Agencies. <https://www.arts.gov/news/press-releases/2021/american-rescue-plan-grants-local-arts-agencies>
- [4] National Endowment for the Arts, American Rescue Plan Grants to Arts Organizations. <https://www.arts.gov/news/press-releases/2022/nea-announces-american-rescue-plan-grants-arts-organizations>
- [5] U.S. Department of the Treasury, State and Local Fiscal Recovery Funds. <https://home.treasury.gov/policy-issues/coronavirus/assistance-for-state-local-and-tribal-governments/state-and-local-fiscal-recovery-funds>
- [6] National League of Cities, Cities and Towns Navigate the 2026 SLFRF Spending Deadline. <https://www.nlc.org/article/2025/03/13/cities-and-towns-navigate-the-2026-slfrf-spending-deadline/>
- [7] National League of Cities, Ways that Cities Are Directing ARPA Dollars Toward the Arts. <https://www.nlc.org/article/2023/03/13/ways-that-cities-are-directing-arpa-dollars-toward-the-arts/>
- [8] Pennsylvania Department of Community & Economic Development, COVID-19 ARPA PA Arts and Culture Recovery Program. <https://dced.pa.gov/programs/covid-19-arpa-pa-arts-and-culture-recovery-program-pacr/>
- [9] Assembly for the Arts, Cuyahoga County ARPA funds for arts nonprofits and creative workers. <https://assemblycle.org/cuyahoga-county-to-award-3-3-million-in-american-rescue-plan-act-funds-to-cuyahoga-arts-culture-and-assembly-for-the-arts/>
- [10] Baltimore Civic Fund, 2025 ARPA Artist Grant Fund. <https://www.baltimorecivicfund.org/2025-arpa-artist-grant-fund-1>
- [11] Baltimore City, ARPA Insight Stories: Revitalizing the Arts in Baltimore. <https://www.baltimorecity.gov/morp/news/arpa-insight-stories-revitalizing-the-arts-in-baltimore>
- [12] Arts Midwest, Public Funding for the Arts in the Midwest: 2026 by the Numbers. <https://artsmidwest.org/resources/research-data/public-funding-for-the-arts-in-the-midwest-2026-by-the-numbers/>

About this brief. This PDF is generated from `data/reports/the-arpa-cliff.json` in the public research repository at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research using the build script `scripts/build-pdfs.mjs`. Every figure shown in this brief is derived from the same JSON dataset and the primary sources listed above. Corrections and source updates may be submitted at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research/issues or by emailing info@bitcoinforthearts.org.

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